

Subject Description Form

Subject Code	APSS2S03																			
Subject Title	Understanding Learning Difficulties																			
Credit Value	3																			
Level	2																			
GUR Requirements Intended to Fulfill	This subject intends to fulfill the following requirement(s) : ☐ Healthy Lifestyle ☐ AI and Data Analytics (AIDA) ☐ Innovation and Entrepreneurship (IE) ☐ Languages and Communication Requirement (LCR) ☐ Leadership Education and Development (LEAD) ☒ Service-Learning ☐ Cluster-Area Requirement (CAR) ☐ Human Nature, Relations and Development [CAR A] ☐ Science, Technology and Environment [CAR D] ☐ Chinese History and Culture [CAR M] ☐ Cultures, Organizations, Societies and Globalization [CAR N] ☐ China-Study Requirement ☐ Yes or ☐ No ☐ Writing and Reading Requirements ☐ English or ☐ Chinese																			
Pre-requisite / Co-requisite/ Exclusion	NIL																			
Assessment Methods	<table border="1" style="width: 100%; border-collapse: collapse; text-align: center;"> <thead> <tr> <th style="width: 40%;">100% Continuous Assessment</th><th style="width: 30%;">Individual Assessment</th><th style="width: 30%;">Group Assessment</th></tr> </thead> <tbody> <tr> <td>1. In-class assignments in seminars</td><td>--</td><td>10%</td></tr> <tr> <td>2. Presentation of service plan & work</td><td>--</td><td>25%</td></tr> <tr> <td>3. Reflective journals</td><td>25%</td><td>--</td></tr> <tr> <td>4. Performance in service-learning activities</td><td>30%</td><td>--</td></tr> <tr> <td>5. E-learning module (for student) "Learn to Serve, Serve to Learn:</td><td>10%</td><td>--</td></tr> </tbody> </table>		100% Continuous Assessment	Individual Assessment	Group Assessment	1. In-class assignments in seminars	--	10%	2. Presentation of service plan & work	--	25%	3. Reflective journals	25%	--	4. Performance in service-learning activities	30%	--	5. E-learning module (for student) "Learn to Serve, Serve to Learn:	10%	--
100% Continuous Assessment	Individual Assessment	Group Assessment																		
1. In-class assignments in seminars	--	10%																		
2. Presentation of service plan & work	--	25%																		
3. Reflective journals	25%	--																		
4. Performance in service-learning activities	30%	--																		
5. E-learning module (for student) "Learn to Serve, Serve to Learn:	10%	--																		

	Introduction to Service-Learning", developed by SLLO (Passing the online quiz of the e-learning module)	
	• The grade is calculated according to the percentage assigned; • The completion and submission of all component assignments are required for passing the subject; and • Student must pass all component(s) if he/she is to pass the subject.	
Objectives	The subject aims to: 1. develop a general understanding of the concepts and practices of learning difficulties (LD) through service-learning activities; 2. nurture a sense of civic responsibility and community engagement in our students; 3. cultivate an awareness of the needs, as well as the strengths, of individuals with learning difficulties; 4. equip students with knowledge and skills in providing initial support to children and youth with learning difficulties.	
Intended Learning Outcomes <i>(Note 1)</i>	Upon completion of subject, students will be able to: a. Apply knowledge of basic types of learning difficulties to recognize and understand the complex needs of underprivileged children and youth with learning difficulties, demonstrating empathy and heightened sensitivity toward their challenges.; b. Demonstrate empathy and civic responsibility when working and connecting with children and youth with learning difficulties, developing genuine dialogues and meaningful exchanges that reflect their commitment as responsible citizens.; c. Apply acquired knowledge and skills to develop service activities that support individuals with learning difficulties, critically evaluate their effectiveness with reference to changes in service recipients, while recognizing their civic responsibility to address complex issues in the service setting.; d. Reflect on their role and responsibilities both as future professionals in their chosen discipline and as responsible citizens, demonstrating understanding of the linkage between service-learning activities and academic content, while examining their development of empathy, social responsibility, and civic engagement through personal growth and academic enhancement.	
Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus	This is a 2-semester subject to be conducted in Semester Two and Summer Term in Hong Kong Lectures and seminars (Semester 2)	

(Note 2)	The lectures and seminars of this course will cover the main topics as indicated below and are designed to inform the students of essential knowledge and basic methodologies relevant to learning difficulties. 1. Conceptualization of learning difficulties 2. Classification and identification of different major types of learning difficulties 3. Interventions paradigms and skills in supporting individuals with learning difficulties; psychosocial principles of effective goal selection in working with learning difficulties. 4. Discussion of social issues relevant to learning difficulties; misconceptions, potential pitfalls in prevention and intervention. 5. Ethical consideration over service delivery and research on learning difficulties Service-Learning Activities (Over Semester 2 and Summer term) The rationales and the significance of the students' community engagement to the potential client will be as an objective of university education; also explain how service learning is related to community engagement and the benefits to the recipients and service providers.
Teaching/Learning Methodology (Note 3)	Lectures & Presentations The lectures and seminars are designed to introduce the students to the relevant issues in this subject. They also provide a student forum to discuss these issues. There will be opportunities for small group discussions, assignment, and presentations to explore these issues in greater depth. Service-Learning Activities Service-Learning activities in this subject will emphasize getting to know children or young people with learning difficulties. The nature of the service varies. They can be involved in the planning or rendering of service to clients in non-government organizations (NGOs) service centers or partner schools, researching on issues of learning difficulties, under the supervision and guidance of the project teaching team. In all cases, students will be facilitated to interact with the service clients to understand their needs. Students will be arranged to work either in teams or individually depending on their own study schedule. They will be given opportunities to: ♦ carry out interviews with and observation of clients with learning difficulties; ♦ work with experience frontline workers to formulate service activities and plans according to their knowledge about the needs and strengths of the clients; ♦ assist in the delivery of service and implementation of training activities for LD. Students will be given supervision and support in their service. They are required to be proactive and reflective in-service learning and be informed the proper attitude and manner as service agent. Each student will be required to submit several reflective service logs that serve as a cumulative record of and reflections upon jobs done.

	Students should always be punctual in attending their service-learning activities sessions. In case of absence or inability to attend a service session for a personal or other valid reason, prior notice should be made to the course instructor at least 1 day before the involved session. During the process, students should under no circumstance take photos of the clients (children and parents) without prior consent from both the clients and supervisors.					
Assessment Methods in Alignment with Intended Learning Outcomes (Note 4)	Specific assessment methods/tasks	% weighting	Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)			
			a	b	c	d
	1. In-class assignments in seminars (group)	10%	✓		✓	
	2. Presentation of Service Plan & Work (group)	25%	✓		✓	✓
	3. Reflective journals (individual)	25%	✓		✓	✓
	4. Performance in service-learning activities (individual)	30%	✓	✓	✓	
	5. E-learning module (for student) "Learn to Serve, Serve to Learn: Introduction to Service-Learning", developed by SLLO (individual)	10% (Passing the online quiz of the e-learning module)				✓
	Total	100 %				
	Explanation of the appropriateness of the assessment methods in assessing the intended learning outcomes: The assessment methods are strategically designed to evaluate students' comprehensive understanding and application of service-learning principles established through the foundational E-learning module "Learn to Serve, Serve to Learn: Introduction to Service-Learning" developed by SLLO. This introductory module provides students with essential knowledge about service-learning concepts, ethics, and reflective practices that underpin all subsequent assessment activities. The class discussions and assignments are designed to help students learn and engage their attention to the relevant issues discussed, building upon the theoretical framework established in the E-learning module. Students are required to form groups of three to four to actively participate in class discussions and activities, applying the collaborative principles learned through the initial online training. Each student will be required to engage in a total of 40 hours of service related to learning difficulties within one semester. Drawing from the service-learning					

	principles and ethical guidelines covered in the E-learning module, students will develop a good understanding of the needs of service recipients and prepare a service-learning project plan. Students will be observed and evaluated on their performance and attitude in service delivery, namely adequateness in pre-service preparation, responsibility, degree of engagement with service recipients, response appropriateness, communication and teamwork with other students and service supervisors. Each student will be required to submit 4 individual reflective service journals during the service delivery stage (each around one A4-sized page). The journals should be considered as a cumulative record of jobs done, with detailed description of carefully selected interactions and events, applying the reflective practices taught in the E-learning module. Students can indicate struggles and successes encountered in the process and share their feelings and thoughts, demonstrating their ability to engage in meaningful reflection as established through the foundational online training. After the service delivery stage, students will be required to do a short presentation about their service-learning experiences. During the presentation, students are expected to demonstrate a clear understanding of clients' needs, a logical theoretically based analysis of their situation with careful selection and detailed description of critical events and processes, and an ability to raise genuine discussion and reflection, all grounded in the comprehensive service-learning framework provided by the initial E-learning module.	
Student Study Effort Expected	Class contact:	
	Lectures A total of 6 lectures will be held from week 1 to 6, during which essential knowledge and skills about working with LD clients will be introduced.	18 Hrs.
	Case discussion, skill consultation & project presentation Over the seminar sessions from week 7 to 11. Instructors will be available for discussion and service consultation. Week 12 and 13 are for students' presentation of service-learning experiences.	21 Hrs.
	Other student study effort:	
	Self-study & planning Recommended readings and articles will be posted on Blackboard. Students can discuss the themes and ideas from the readings over seminars and lectures. Also, students are expected to prepare service plans with reference to the materials.	30 Hrs.
	Completion of E-learning module "Learn to Serve, Serve to Learn: Introduction to Service-Learning"	10 hrs
	Service preparation and delivery	40 Hrs.

	Service sessions will be held within the period from <u>week 3 of Semester 2 to week 6 of Summer Term</u>. Two major sites will be provided for students to engage in services on supporting children or youth with learning difficulties: 1. <i>Local partner schools and local NGO agencies</i> – Delivery of after-school tutoring programs for students with learning difficulties or low academic achievement. 2. <i>Service Activities for children with LD on the campus of the Hong Kong Polytechnic University</i> - Participate in the planning and the delivery of training activities and related research work. <i>Other off-campus service opportunities may also be arranged in an ad hoc manner.</i>	
	▪ Preparation of reflective journals A total of 4 reflective service journals with clear and detailed description of events and processes and personal reflection and insight.	10 Hrs.
	Total student study effort	129 Hrs.
Reading List and References	<u>Recommended Text</u> Banks, T., Obiakor, F. E., & Algozzine, B. (2017). Preparing leaders to work with students with diverse learning needs. In F. E. Obiakor, T. Banks, A. F. Rotatori & C. Utley (Eds.), <i>Leadership matters in the education of students with special needs in the 21st century; leadership matters in the education of students with special needs in the 21st century</i> (pp. 39-60, Chapter x, 209 Pages). Lerner, J. W., & Johns, B. H. (2012). <i>Learning disabilities and related mild disabilities: Teaching strategies and new directions</i>. Belmont: Wadsworth Cengage Learning. Verma, I. (2021). <i>Universal design 2021: From special to mainstream solutions</i> (Vol. 282). <u>Supplementary</u> Chinn, S. J. (2004). <i>The trouble with Maths: A practical guide to helping learners with numeracy difficulties</i>. London: Routledge Falmer. Ho, C. S. H, Wong, H. Y.-K., Lo, C.-M, Chan, D. W., Chung, K. K.-H. and Lo, S. C (2014). Helping Children with Reading Disability in Chinese: The Response to Intervention Approach with Effective Evidence-Based Curriculum. In X. Chen, Q. Wang & Y. C. Luo (Ed.), <i>Reading Development and Difficulties in Monolingual and Bilingual Chinese Children Literacy Studies 8</i> (pp.103-124). Netherlands: Springer. Lai A.C. (2011). <i>Understanding dyslexia and overcoming reading difficulties</i> (6th Edition). H.K.: Sun Yan Publication (HK) Ltd.	

	Taylor, I., & Taylor, M. M. (1995). Writing and literacy in Chinese, Korean, and Japanese. Philadelphia: John Benjamins. Wong, B. Y. L., Graham, L., Hoskyn, M. & Berman, J. (2008). <i>The ABCs of Learning Disabilities</i>. London, UK: Elsevier Academic Press.
--	---

Note 1: Intended Learning Outcomes

Intended learning outcomes should state what students should be able to do or attain upon completion of the subject. Subject outcomes are expected to contribute to the attainment of the overall programme outcomes.

Note 2: Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus

The syllabus should adequately address the intended learning outcomes. At the same time over-crowding of the syllabus should be avoided.

Note 3: Teaching/Learning Methodology

This section should include a brief description of the teaching and learning methods to be employed to facilitate learning, and a justification of how the methods are aligned with the intended learning outcomes of the subject.

Note 4: Assessment Method

This section should include the assessment method(s) to be used and its relative weighting, and indicate which of the subject intended learning outcomes that each method purports to assess. It should also provide a brief explanation of the appropriateness of the assessment methods in assessing the intended learning outcomes.